could read its terms in the newspapers.[132] Anglo-Afghan relations appeared to be taking a turn for the worse.

For the Indian government, the inability of the Home government to temper its demands was extremely frustrating. The worst possible scenario in its eyes was for Dobbs to leave Kabul without any form of an agreement. As Reading explained to Montagu: 'If I am insistent it is because of my desire to avoid failure, which would stimulate Mohammedans and other extremists in India, and would necessitate continued heavy military expenditure, with all its opportunities for creating [a] troublesome position with [the] Legislature.'[133] Furthermore, for the Indian government, the pan-Islamic and nationalistic sentiment that was amassing in South Asia and being directed against the British empire was another crucial reason for fixing its relations with Afghanistan:

We are supposed by Moslem India to be bent upon crushing Turkey... We are supposed to have turned against Persia after failing to impose our domination upon her... This being so, failure to make [a] treaty of friendship with Afghanistan would be regarded by Moslem India as further proof of a fixed policy of antagonism to independent Moslem nations.[134]

Desperate to try to convince London of the need to find a resolution to the situation, the viceroy even enlisted the help of his key officials, including the chief commissioner of the North West Frontier Province, Sir John Maffey, who entirely agreed with Reading's justifications for wanting a treaty of friendship with Afghanistan.[135] Montagu had no hesitation, however, in dismissing the Indian government's protests, arguing that he was simply unconvinced that a breach with Afghanistan would have such a negative impact on India, or that a pis aller treaty would have such positive effects.[136] When the Cabinet met again, on 3 November, to discuss the issue, it concurred with Montagu's judgement: no pis aller agreement was to be negotiated without disclosure of the Soviet-Afghan treaty.[137]